1942 ('Rifle N. Winchester 448261' is added.)

"I went to the Labour Exchange, registered for military service"

Jan 1 1942
… At 7.30, feeling my eyes water, I saw smoke coming from a drawer of Mr. Holland's desk. This came from a towel, which must have been burning since 6.0. Unfortunately, the d - place was not burnt down!

Jan 19 1942
This morning I overslept and was rather late. I was told that Mr Burgin wished to see me, and was in fear and trembling, but it was only to present our first aid certificates.

Jan 26 1942
Very cold evening … Mr Bellamy looked so like a mummy while asleep, that I pinned a label on to him to that effect. So far no violence! I put 30s into war savings. ... We had a 6d raffle, and I won a box of 36 Kit-Kats! Whoopee!

February 4 1942
... Went to Carlton. Instruction on rumba!...

February 20 1942
Finished skimming through Karl Marx (thank goodness). Jap landing on Bali and Timor. ...

March 4 1942
I still have about 5 Kit-Kats left, and very consoling they are on sentry duty.



A recruiting parade in a Yorkshire town, November 11 1941: a Scammell Pioneer artillery tractor tows a Howitzer. (Perhaps Yorkshire lad Jim saw something like this that encouraged him to join up?)

April 18 1942
… I went to the Labour Exchange, registered for military service.

April 29 1942
Today I underwent my army medical examination, and passed Grade 1, to my great delight. … I met young Steve Clark. We went by tram to Sheffield, and then walked to Bramall Lane Pavilion, arriving about 1. First came an intelligence test, fitting pieces of pattern to the correct pattern … rather interesting. After this came the medical exam … Finally there was a short interview with a Major ...



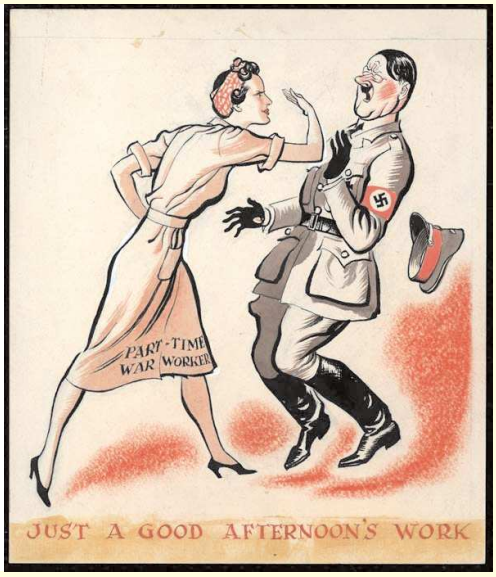
Drill on the parade of a south coast town, 1941. Picture (from Imperial War Museum) by Edward Ardizzone. (See the soldier who's fallen down flat?)

May 12 1942
... Mother and I were off to Blackpool by the 9.25 train. ...
First we found that the RAF had taken over most of the boarding houses. Then we found that Mon., Tues. and Wed. of this week are the tradesmen's holiday, so we couldn't easily get a meal at a café.

May 13 1942
The place is full of airmen, who are drilling all over the promenade. There are a large number of soldiers here too. Many of the hotels have been taken over. For dinner we had some tinned rabbit we brought, heated up. It is as well that Mother brought most of the food we shall need…



Jim's enthusiasm to enter the war was perhaps boosted by posters like the one here by Frank Newbould (1942), featuring Salisbury Cathedral.



"I am to report to the Royal Armoured Corps, Catterick, On July 2nd. I am very excited about it"

June 15 1942
… H.G. parade at the Corpn. ARP [Air Raid Precaution] place at Mary St. We all went into the gas chamber to test our respirators. Afterwards some of them went in without their masks to 'smell the gas', and came out in a hurry. Parade over by 8, so I cleaned my boots and shoes and read some more Pepys. Serious crisis in the Libyan fighting.

June 22 1942
… Mother has got herself a job at R'ham Forge [Rotherham Forge and Rolling Mills], starting tomorrow! … The fall of Tobruk confirmed.

June 24 1942
As I was just going back to work at breakfast time, Dad called me back, and I discovered that my papers had arrived. I am to report to the Royal Armoured Corps, Catterick, On July 2nd. I am very excited about it, and especially pleased that I am going to be in the unit I wanted. Everyone at work seemed very interested, and I spent nearly as much time talking as working …

June 25 1942
Sirens sounded last night about 1.25, though no air raids in this area. The warning was the first for nearly 6 months, but we ignored it.

June 29 1942
… Managed to buy a razor from a barber's shop opposite. Half a crown was less than I expected, and revelation that I am going up produces remarkable sympathy! … In the evening I took my equipment up to the Home Guard to hand in. Fortunately I only had to retain the essentials of my kit, so my battered tin hat and semi-repaired camouflage net went back, as well as other items. Dad and the Q.M.S fitted me out with a brand new battle-dress, much to my delight. I had not wished to go in these ancient trousers. …

I saw Vic, Sgt. Scott, who wished me luck, and some of the other lads. I am beginning to feel a bit queasy, now that there is so little time left, but san fairy ann! [Jokey corruption of French *Ça ne fait rien* - 'It doesn't matter'. Thought to go back to world war 1 British soldiers in France.]

July 1 1942
[He winds up his affairs and visits relatives] ... then to Granny's where the garden flourishes like anything … spent the evening packing and contriving and planning, in a confusion of haste and energy. Dad got my list from the H.G., and says Smith and 3 others are going on the same train! I am a mixture of worry …, eagerness (a beret) and 'now it's coming'!

Jim's mother Elsie took a factory job around the time he joined the army. Possibly she responded to the posters like the one above, urging women to do war work. Or maybe she wanted to take her mind off his departure?

Posters are from the Imperial War Museum.



Items joining the ration in 1941 included cheese, clothing, eggs and coal. Jim reports on **March 9 1942:** '… Since we are short of firewood, I applied for a sleeper from the company. For dinner, Shepherd's pie made with corned beef, and batter pudding made without eggs – a real substitute meal.'

On **March 10 1942** Jim recorded: '… I went to the Carlton, to the learners' dance. There were a couple of raffles for Warship Week.' Warship Weeks were fund-raising campaigns in which towns would raise money to build and adopt naval ships. Rotherham raised enough to 'adopt' HMS Rotherham, an 'R' class destroyer.



"Today I entered the army. Mum and Dad came to the stn."

July 2 1942
Today I entered the army. I awoke at 7, got into my uniform, had an egg for breakfast, and with some slight hurry pushed off. Mother and Dad came down to the stn. and saw me off. Jim Smith and Nobby Clarke were there, and both are going in the same lot … We travelled together to Catterick … Nobby and I got the same bunk.

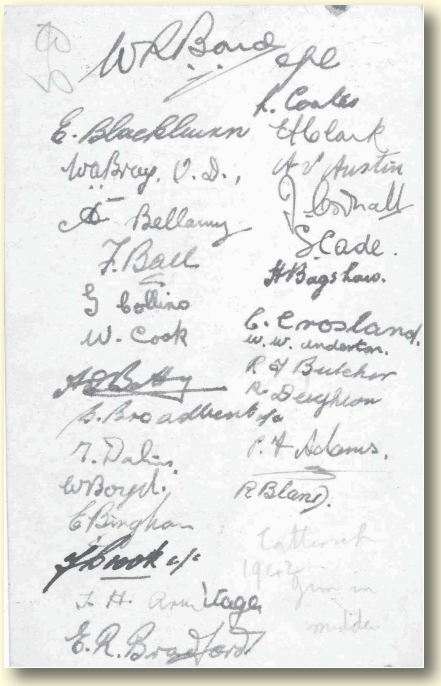
Things seem pretty decent here, and the food is all right anyway. The N.C.O.s [Non Commissioned Officers] are all right too. You don't quite know what you are doing, but there hasn't been much to do anyway. The weather is very hot, my uniform and boots feel uncomfortable. … The lads seem a decent crowd. I guess it won't be so bad.

Mr. Churchill announced that we have lost 50,000 men in Libya in this battle.

July 3 1942
Up on reveille at 6.15, though I was awake an hour earlier. Breakfast all right, and then they marched us off for medical inspection, vaccination and inoculation. The inspection was a farce, but the rest was hell ... as soon as we got back into the waiting room half of them went over like ninepins ... in a couple of hours my arms were almost too painful to move. … We hung about all evening, with no more guts than a lot of jellyfish. … Nobby and I had our supper at the NAAFI , cheap and good, but a long queue.
[NAAFI standing for Navy, Army and Air Force Institutes - an organisation running various facilities on British military bases]



Above: a group photo of Jim's squadron at Catterick training camp, North Yorkshire, taken around August 1942. Jim thought to be fifth from left on the middle row.



Above: the back of Jim's army group photo, signed by everybody - even Broadbent the diary vandal.



Right: Jim Dixon. Date unknown, but probably taken soon after arrival in army, aged 18. How proud Jim was to get that army beret!



Right: another cartoon from the collection Home Guard Humour
(It sounds as though Jim was expected to wear his Home Guard battle dress in the regular army, so it's understandable he was pleased when the Home Guard fixed him up with a new one.)

"We had a marvellous night – half dying, and the rest wishing they were"

July 4 (Sat) 1942
We had a marvellous night – half dying, and the rest wishing they were. … We are supposed to have 48 hrs off duty to recover, but we had to go and draw some more kit, and the Squadron C.O. [Commanding Officer] came to talk to us. … They have issued us with nearly everything I brought, which makes it silly to tell us to bring stuff. In Libya, violent fighting reported in the El Alamein area, but no definite result yet.

July 5 1942
… It being Sunday, we had an extra hour in bed. A decent breakfast – bacon, bread and dip, just like home. No duties, but a terrible lot of cleaning, floor, windows, equipment and self. … I wrote my first letter home …

July 6 1942
… Our main duty for the day was to undergo various tests. The written ones were interesting, and not too bad. We had to do an agility test, running around in pumps shoving rings on sticks …It seems ages since I joined, as if it were my lifetime.

July 7 1942
Still more tests. The practical tests consisted of assembling 8 small articles, such as a lock etc. I didn't do too badly at that, but the hearing test showed that I was rather deaf … Apart from this I blancoed all my webbing – a grand job – we all loved it…. Our first and only issue of cleaning materials was made – my tin of metal polish proved unusable and worthless. It seems to me the only way to keep your sanity is to decide that the whole damn thing doesn't matter anyway.

July 9 1942
Our training started this morning. We had some drill under Cpl. Bond and Sgt. Coates, a spot of P.T. and some map-reading. It wasn't too bad, but during the 2nd drill period we had 'salute to the front', and with standing still so long I fainted away.

We got our first pay – 10s. … I wrote to Grandmother – I think I shall have to circularise my relations to keep up with Nobby's flood of correspondence.

July 10 1942
More drill and P.T. …If what we get is no worse than this I stand it, though we keep getting ominous warnings about the next 6 weeks. … I volunteered for fatigues at the cookhouse. Not so bad, even getting the eyes out of potatoes, and a decent supper. Another letter from Mother and Dad. I sent one to Grandma. Rommel is still held up before El Alamein.

July 14 1942
Today we started our training in earnest. A bloody rush it was too. Two drill and two P.T. periods. … Lane, the P.T. Sergeant, seems a bastard. … I had a letter from Mum and Dad, with 10s. My store of cash is accumulating! Nobody seems precisely enthusiastic about gym, but we are keen to get our drill smart, so that we can pass out.

July 17 1942
... Relations between myself and Armitage very hostile...

July 20 1942
We had to wear our gas masks from 9 to 11, which included a drill period. We made an absolute mess of it! More trouble from Armitage and Co., the best thing seems to be to ignore them. My knowledge of first aid and map-reading has gained me kudos. Also, the education officer seemed to think my language qualifications good enough for an instructor.

Through 1941 and 1942, British and Axis forces fought a see-saw series of battles for control of Libya and parts of Egypt. Germany's Field Marshal Erwin Rommel took Tobruk, Libya, from the British Eighth Army in June 1942. The British then fell back on their first line of defence in Egypt, Mersa Matruh.

The First Battle of Alamein (1 - 27 July 1942) halted an advance by the Axis forces into Egypt, but was a stalemate, and the 8th Army had suffered over 13,000 casualties. The second battle of El Alamein occurred in October 1942, when forces under Montgomery decisively defeated Axis forces.



Above: poster shows four British infantrymen running towards a group of surrendering German soldiers. (Pics from Imperial War Museum)



Left: a picture by Tom Keay of airmen doing gas drill in Blackpool, 1941, illustrates Jim's diary entry of July 20.

“I found my diary in pieces on my bed”

July 25 1942
A great day! We paraded before the Major, he inspected our belts, and we passed out. … After dinner, Fritz, Nobby and I strolled down to Camp Centre, and after tea we took the bus to Richmond. … It was our first taste of freedom, and we didn’t half feel devils strolling about in berets. …. Donkin and Batty came in drunk – they were really terribly funny!

July 30 1942
... I was nearly late getting dressed, and Sgt. Heaton dropped on me heavily. ...Nobby had a brush with Broadbent, and showed a good deal of spirit...

Aug 5 1942
Letter from home, bombs dropped in daylight on Clifton Park, but little harm done. … The names of the four L/Cpls announced – Broadbent, Burns and the two Brooks. It is something that Armitage has not got any stripes.

Aug 8 1942
Route march at 7.30, in battle order. Down towards Richmond, up the river – fording across it in boots, and back through Richmond. Water only a foot deep, but Cpl. Bonds fell full length.

Aug 17 1942
. … I found my diary in pieces on my bed, and was told that Broadbent had done it. I put him on a charge, which should stop his pretty little games.

Aug 18 1942
Last night, when Broadbent came in, he said that he had only torn out two of the leaves, and, after a period of truculence, apologised heavily. I let him off, rather to the disgust of Cpl. Bettsworth and the others.… The squad photos are available, and we all had a time collecting everyone’s autograph on the backs of the photos.

Aug 19 1942
...Everyone is very excited about leave, and news of the raid on Dieppe caused a lot of speculation about a second front, and leave being [unclear - probably ‘off’].



Civilians were required to carry gas masks for fear the enemy would drop poison gas bombs.(Alarmingly, the filters contained dangerous blue asbestos until 1956!)

Below: soldier writing a letter home. Picture by John Minton, 1943 (from Imperial War Museum)





British soldiers going on leave after participating in the allied commando raid on Dieppe chat to an American nurse in a railway carriage. (Imperial War Museum photo)

The August 19 raid on the French port failed disastrously. Almost 60 per cent of the 6,086 men who made it ashore were killed, wounded or captured. (The Soviet Union, invaded by Germany, had pressured for a second front in France to force the Germans to move at least 40 divisions from the Eastern Front.)

Aug 23 1942
… I awoke with a slight hangover, and heard some very funny tales about the others last night – Batty came back semi-conscious, and Ball, Brook [or Brooks 2?] and Donkin wet their beds. Then lots of bullshit [spit and polish] for a church parade.

Aug 24 1942
… Everybody very excited about leave. Bus to the stn. and home, standing all the way – we didn't care. Met Mother as I reached our house. A grand dinner, with pancakes.

Aug 29 1942
… In the evening to the Empire (Nelson Eddy in 'The Chocolate Soldier'). Later to the NAAFI, and then on the booze. I had a pint at the College, and 3 at the County Borough, meeting a Home Guard lad there. I was properly foxed but staggered home. … couldn't sober up, so had to grin and face the music. Sick when I got upstairs.

Aug 30 1942
A terrific hangover … very angry with myself too.

Aug 31 1942
The morning spent in packing, polishing etc. … Mother insisted on my taking a lot of food with me. … I travelled to Darlington with a couple of drunken M.P.s [presumably military police, not members of Parliament!], very funny … arrived Catterick 8.45 … I was certainly very sorry to leave Mother and Dad.

Sept 14 1942
On gunnery all day, and shall be for the next fortnight, I am afraid. We have as inspector Cpl. M…., who is a perfect sod. Also, the place stinks of bullshit [polish or paint] – DON'T lean against the wall!



A cartoon by Illingworth, showing Hitler knifing Stalin

In June 1941 Germany had attacked Russia, despite having signed a non-aggression pact with the Soviets in 1939. The Soviets put up fierce resistance. The brutal Battle of Stalingrad took place from August 23 1942 to February 2 1943, when the Germans were defeated.

"16 of the Regt. were still missing at Lights Out. It was a real bugger"

Sept 19 (Sat) 1942
Up at 3.45. No time for cocoa or wash. … Up hills at about 6 MPH, over heather and moor, a real marathon. Tich and Butcher were the first to fall out in our squad, but soon they were tumbling all over the place. The main body, including me, arrived back at 2.15, after an estimated 25 miles. The last of our squad got back about 4, but 16 of the Regt. were still missing at Lights Out. It was a real bugger. I don't know how I managed the last mile. Lads just dropped where they stood. … I stayed in all day, and most of them were limping about in slippers. As Sgt. Major Davy said, the Colonel is a 'bastard haggis-eating Scotchman'.

Oct 3 1942
This morning there was a route march, but I escaped it by reporting sick. I had sprained my shoulder wrestling with Hoppy last night, though really it was a bit of a try-on. …

Oct 4 (Sunday) 1942
Church parade. For once I really was properly polished etc. … In the evening to the Garrison Theatre to see Clark Gable in 'Strange Cargo'. …Hitler looks as far from capturing Stalingrad as ever.

Nov 7 1942
On account of being a few minutes late on parade we were given an hour's drill in full marching order.



Recruits to the Royal Ordnance Corps with a drill instructor at Woolwich barracks, London, August 1940.

(Photo from Imperial War Museum)

"Only about 20 mins [tank driving] each, the rest telling dirty jokes round a big wood fire"

Nov 22 1942
On church parade. The Squadron Orderly, Sgt. Taylor, sent me off for dirty boots, and I got an hour or so of fatigues after dinner. It was scrubbing at the Sgt.'s Mess, and enabled me to replace therefrom the spoon I lost on Friday.

Nov 26 1942
Out all day, driving Valentines. Only about 20 mins each, the rest telling dirty jokes round a big wood fire. A very easy tank to steer.

Nov 27 1942
At the G.P. wing again. We did the Churchill gearbox, the most remarkable system ever devised by a lunatic! A letter from home, with an offer from the Ministry of Labour for an engineering cadetship, on Mr. Field's recommendation. I do not intend to accept it.The Russian attack round Stalingrad and the Don seems to have made remarkable progress.



Children watch activity around a Matilda Mk II tank of 44th Royal Tank Regiment in Finden, Sussex, during exercises, March 4 1941 (Imperial War Museum)

Jim was told on Oct 23 he was to be a driver-mechanic in 142 squad. Jim mentioned receiving a letter offering an engineering cadetship. Presumably acceptance of this would have kept him from fighting abroad. Possibly his parents arranged it.

Dec 9 1942
There being a route march in the afternoon, I reported sick. The M.O. was rather unsympathetic, so I had to go on it.

Dec 14 1942
… Trying to find my class, I wandered in Captain Newall's office, failed to salute him and was heavily sat upon. My opinion of him is more than confirmed.

Dec 16 1942
[Jim was so late departing on leave he didn't get to Rotherham till 3.30. A.M.]
No one up – and no key, so I bedded down in the shelter, but too cold to sleep, so just dozed.

Dec 17 1942
I walked in at breakfast time, and of course Mother and Dad said I should have knocked them up.

Dec 18 1942
My hair cream has separated out into starch and water, but proved still usable.

"Biggest hangover within memory"

Dec 21 1942
… Out with Eric to Sheffield. *Nous bûmes cinq bières ... , et puis allâmes chercher deux filles, mais nous étions trop woozy pour du succès.* ['Franglais' translation: 'We drank five beers ... , and then went to find two girls, but were too drunk to get anywhere.']

Dec 22 1942
… Biggest hangover within memory. Up 10.30, conscious 2.30! … Mother and Dad pretty fed up with me for nights out.

Dec 25 1942
Granny to dinner, chicken, Yorkshire pudding, plum pudding with rum sauce. … Trifle for tea. I heard the King's speech. After tea we went to the Tivoli, then back and played cards till late. Dad made me some hot rum and water to go to bed on.

Dec 26 1942
… Mother insisted on giving me a box full of food! … We all walked down to the station, and waited for the train. Off on the 3.5, feeling very sorry to leave. … Unpacked my case and chatted to the lads, then, after Lights Out, sat in front of the fire, smoking one of the cigars Dad gave me, and feeling homesick – very much.

Dec 27 1942
… Feeling homesick again, and seriously considering sending in the cadetship papers.

Dec 29 1942
… After very anxious consideration, even filling in the papers, I decided not to apply for the cadetship.

Dec 31 1942
Lights allowed on till 1, for New Year's Eve concert, so up late. Many pillow-fights. The end of the Old Year, and the completion of 6 months in the army. An icy wind howling outside. Are we downhearted? Are we ————-!

1943 "enemy raid on London last night; we saw plenty of flak and searchlights"

[After Catterick other training postings followed]

Feb 20 1943
Awakened by the guard at 4.30 … All packed up, and off in bright moonlight. …. Five of us, all weighed down with kitbags etc. We got a train right through from Darlington to King's Cross, seats all the way. We hurried through London … and got to Hythe about 6 (we didn't find out till 5 min. before leaving where we were going).

March 2 1943
...Heavy gunfire from up the coast...

March 4 1943
An enemy raid on London last night; we saw plenty of flak and searchlights. I meant to stay up at the tank park all day, but found out in mid-morning I was on a gunnery course...

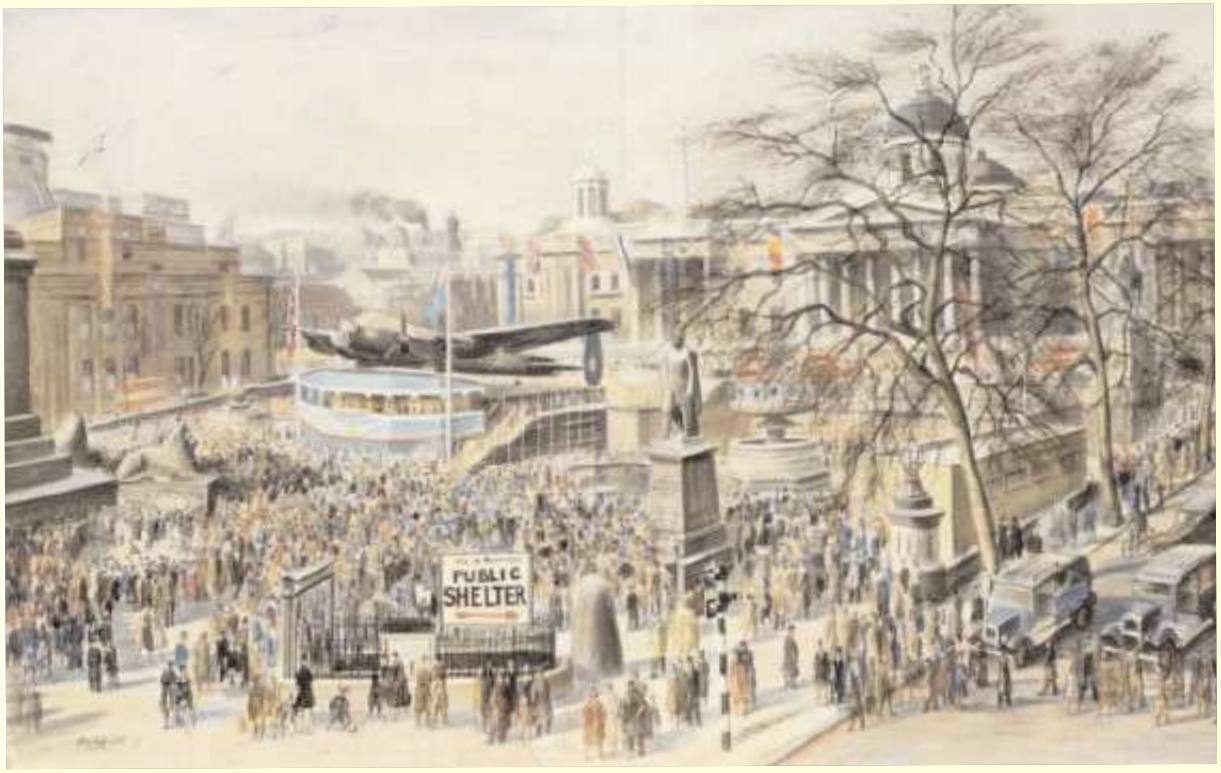


Eros covered in wartime savings posters, Piccadilly Circus (Pictures from Imperial war Museum)

March 14 1943
…to Trafalgar Square, and saw the Lancaster bomber behind the Column, one of the 'Wings for Victory' ideas. [picture below] … to Piccadilly Circus. Eros, however, was boarded up. So many officers, I was too tired to salute them. Anyway, so many Yanks I couldn't tell which were which. [I think he means the Americans had more glamorous uniforms, so the British couldn't tell officers from other ranks.] Dinner at a canteen in the crypt of St. Martin's-in-the-Fields. ... Back to Trafalgar Square, where there was a Communist meeting. Very patriotic - they ended with 'The King' and the 'Internationale'.

This 1943 Picture by Roland Pitchforth shows huge crowds gathering to mark the fund-raising 'Wings for Victory Week' and see the Lancaster bomber in Trafalgar Square.

In 1943 the Germans began 'hit-and run' raids in which groups of fast aircraft appeared suddenly to drop bombs. The bombing was not as heavy as in 1940-41, but caused casualties because the speed meant people had less time to shelter. The night of **3/4 March 1943** was the one when panicked crowds died in a crush accident on the steps of Bethnal Green tube station.



During 1943, Jim's diary reported training postings in various parts of the United Kingdom. He also excitedly recorded allied advances in German-occupied Sicily and mainland Italy. In November he learned that he was to be transferred to the Manchester regiment and soon afterwards he was sent abroad - to Italy. Jim had one last evening of fun before the big news came - a dance, during a posting to Wales:

Oct 16 (Sat) 1943
… I got a truck at 2 to Tenby … We picked a dozen land-girls up on the way. I went around with Sykes, Anderson and a couple of other blokes. … We sampled the local bitter (quite decent) and went to a dance (excellent). … Maybourne, Spotswood and Thompson were quite merry – the first two did an old-fashioned waltz together, and me and Tommy the conga! We had some of the WLA [Women's Land Army] in the truck again coming back. No fun and games, but they have a good repertoire of army songs.

"we are to get 14 days leave, then go abroad"

November 9 1943
… A considerable shock administered, on being told that we are to get 14 days leave, then go abroad.

November 10 1943
…we signed the 'death warrant'. [embarkation form]

November 27 1943
... made our wills....

December 9 1943
Instructions issued as to dress and packing for move. A grand time was had by all, trying to get a mass of kit into the big pack.

December 10 1943
...Naturally they changed their minds about the contents and I repacked.



Above: land girls and British soldiers at a dance near the Women's Land Army forestry training camp at Culford, Suffolk, May 1943.
Below: a railway station in wartime.

